Ministry of Housing, Communities & Local Government

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Council Leaders in Worcestershire
By email

29 October 2026

Dear Leaders,

I am writing to set out the outcome of the Government's review of the framework for the local government reorganisation programme and, separately, the Secretary of State's current provisional view on the proposals for local government reorganisation in Worcestershire.

We are grateful for all the work that went into developing proposals and preparing for implementation, and for the patience you have shown throughout this process. We recognise that the review period has not been easy, and do not take for granted your continued commitment to the long-term work needed to fix the foundations and put local government in the best possible position.

Outcome of the programme review

Following the announcement to Parliament on 7 September 2026, the Secretary of State and I have worked with officials to interrogate the key pillars and framework underpinning the Local Government Reorganisation programme, including asking whether the existing unweighted criteria ('criteria') set in February 2025 and the programme's objectives continue to support the policy priorities of the new Government.

We have concluded that the basis of the programme is robust and that the criteria against which proposals have been submitted were both correct on their own terms and continue to support the Government's policy agenda. Following this initial phase of the review, we can therefore confirm that the Government remains committed to delivering Local Government Reorganisation and that we will continue to move forward with the programme based on the criteria, which we hope gives confidence as the programme progresses.

Minded to decision for Worcestershire

Separately from that programme-level review, the Secretary of State and I, in my capacity as Minister for Local Government, Devolution and Regional Growth, are currently minded to implement the **two unitary proposal submitted by Bromsgrove District Council, Malvern Hills District Council, Redditch Borough Council, Worcester City Council and Wychavon District Council.**

Elections to new councils would take place in May 2028, ahead of vesting in April 2029. The proposal, that we are currently minded to make would establish the following new councils:

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Proposed new council	Existing local government areas forming proposed new council (excluding county council)	Population size of proposed new council
North Worcestershire	Bromsgrove District Council Redditch Borough Council Wyre Forest District Council	293,000
South Worcestershire	Malvern Hills District Council Worcester City Council Wychavon District Council	328,000

Consideration of the proposals

This letter sets out our consideration of the performance of each proposal against the criteria and the reasons why we are currently minded to select the preferred proposal. Where relevant, we have also set out areas where we are seeking further information before reaching a final decision. Further detail of the minded to process is set out at the end of this letter.

We have considered the two proposals received from councils in Worcestershire:

- The one unitary proposal from Worcestershire County Council and Wyre Forest District Council
- The two unitary proposal from Bromsgrove District Council, Malvern Hills District Council, Redditch Borough Council, Worcester City Council and Wychavon District Council.

We have assessed each submitted proposal against the six criteria and considered their strengths and weaknesses before reaching this minded to decision.

Both proposals meet all six criteria.

Criterion 1: A proposal should seek to achieve for the whole of the area concerned the establishment of a single tier of local government

The two unitary proposal meets criterion 1.

The proposal for the two unitary option describes demographic differences between the northern and southern areas of Worcestershire to support the case for more locally tailored services. The north has a slightly younger population, while the south has a higher proportion aged 65 and over. It also identifies specific challenges in the north in areas including skills, health and crime. We agree with the case made in the two unitary proposal that these differing demographic profiles would allow each council to shape commissioning, prevention and neighbourhood-based support around its population, and note the intention to retain shared services for a period. In our view, the two unitary proposal would better reflect the different characteristics and priorities of the north and south of the county.

We consider that two councils would bring housing, planning, economic development and service footprints into closer alignment with those local needs. Each could tailor its housing strategy to a sensible geography, with local land supply, affordability and regeneration needs, and focus economic development on its economic areas' sector strengths and workforce. We believe that this more focused approach is a clear advantage of the two unitary proposal.

We recognise that establishing two councils would require existing countywide strategic functions and relationships to be divided. This is inevitable for any options which move away from the two-tier system which allowed for a single upper tier county council covering a whole county, into any future model of two or more unitary councils on the same footprint. But this must always be balanced

against seeking to ensure that the new unitary councils are deemed to be right for the local context, and the wider benefits of councils which are closer to the communities they serve. In this case, we consider the balance favours the two unitary proposal.
Effective coordination on transport, infrastructure, housing, employment and other cross-boundary issues will be essential to the successful transition. We will work with local areas to support them to deliver this well, in line with our wider sector support work, and the funding made available for those undertaking reorganisation

Turning to the one unitary proposal, which also meets criterion 1, we recognise the benefits of bringing housing, planning, and regeneration under one strategic framework. A single council would offer scale, simplicity, and countywide coordination and these merits have been carefully considered. Having considered that two councils would be better placed to respond to the distinct housing and economic priorities of the north and south, we judge that the more focused leadership and locally tailored strategies offered by two councils outweigh the stronger countywide coordination offered by one.

Criterion 2: Unitary local government must be the right size to achieve efficiencies, improve capacity and withstand financial shocks

The two unitary proposal meets criterion 2.

We consider that the distinct geographies, identities and service needs of the north and south justify two councils below the 500,000 population guideline. The guiding principle of 500,000 is not a fixed threshold, and I made clear that councils across the programme could develop proposals for authorities with populations either above or below that figure in statements to Parliament and in discussions with the sector over many months. In this case, this is justified by the different characteristics and needs of the two areas and by the benefits of councils with a clearer local focus. It is also relevant that many single-tier councils, with a median population of around 275,000, have operated effectively across the same key services for decades. The two proposed unitary councils sit above this average. Critical to success will be strong leadership, sufficient capacity and capability, and clear prioritisation of resource to support the transition and ensure high performance of these services going forward. Each council would have a strong population base to support long-term sustainability and growth, while responding more closely to its area's needs.

We have considered projected efficiencies separately from longer-term financial sustainability. We recognise that establishing two councils carries disaggregation costs. The two unitary proposal acknowledges that North Worcestershire would also face greater relative pressures, with higher need and a weaker income base. Nevertheless, our internal analysis finds that both options are likely to represent an overall improvement in sustainability over current structures and improve the ability to withstand financial shocks.

It is also important to say that while reorganisation can contribute to local government sustainability, it is only part of the answer alongside cross-government and sector work on public sector reform and high-cost, demand-led services in adult social care, children's services, SEND and temporary accommodation, for example. Much of that work is underway and supported by new investment alongside a focus on early intervention and prevention.

Turning to the one unitary proposal, which also meets criterion 2, we recognise that it offers the largest tax base and greater capacity to absorb financial and service pressures. Our internal analysis finds that although both options are likely to represent an overall improvement in sustainability, the one unitary proposal performs more strongly. It would avoid the costs and complexity of dividing countywide functions. It also has the stronger short-term savings case, with some uncertainty, even though officials had greater confidence in the savings assumptions overall.

While there are differing levels of benefit and both proposals would contribute to building a more sustainable foundation for local government in the area, we judge that two councils will have a better chance of delivering long term transformation and provide greater opportunities to reduce service demand over time and improve outcomes, which could also support longer-term financial sustainability.

Criterion 3: Unitary structures must prioritise the delivery of high quality and sustainable public services to citizens

The two unitary proposal meets criterion 3.

The two unitary proposal's north-south structure will prioritise improving services by focusing on each area's needs, early intervention and prevention. We judge that, with the support we are delivering to manage the disaggregation period, two separate authorities will enable effective, high-quality service provision for local residents in this area. This is also an opportunity to look at cross-council collaboration alongside localised neighbourhood delivery built around people and place.

We recognise that this proposal requires disaggregation of countywide services and that in any disaggregation there will be concerns about safeguarding, adult social care, public health, children's services, SEND, workforce and leadership capacity, commissioning and established partnerships.

The proposal gives us confidence that these risks are understood and transition can be managed. A safe transfer protocol, joint governance, early risk identification and phased implementation will support the transition. Worcestershire's existing shared services show experience of working across council boundaries. The proposal also cites Dorset and Cumbria as examples of maintaining shared arrangements while transferring responsibilities to separate unitary councils. Together, these measures and examples provide a credible basis for managing the additional cost, complexity and risks of dividing services, through maintaining continuity and enabling later changes to service delivery.

Risks to service continuity, leadership capacity, safeguarding and commissioning must be planned for and reduced as a minimum expectation. Delivery will require clear plans for allocating resources and liabilities, maintaining children's and adult services, managing the workforce and service providers, and retaining shared arrangements where that works most effectively for specific services. The proposal's attention to these requirements supports our confidence that the risks can be managed.

Our department, working in partnership with other government departments, has developed a robust support offer comprising several elements. Funding will enable each area undertaking disaggregation to bring in additional capacity to support a safe transition process. National work to support the leadership pipeline for key roles such as children's and adults' service directors should provide that in the medium term there is adequate capacity and quality to deliver effective and safe services for those that need them.

Taken together, the funding and wider support offer give us confidence that the identified risks to public services during transition and the division of services can be managed if implementation is handled well. As set out in the proposal, the experience of reorganisation in Cumbria demonstrates and gives us further reassurance that well-managed disaggregation can support stronger local accountability while maintaining and improving service outcomes, including continued improvements in children's services following reorganisation.

Turning to the one unitary proposal, which also meets criterion 3, we recognise that keeping countywide services together would limit disruption. It would preserve existing staff, leadership, contracts and partnerships across care, education, special educational needs and disabilities, public health and safeguarding. However, on balance we consider that two councils would be better placed to tailor services, partnerships and economic strategies to the different needs of the more urban, industrial north and the more rural, service-based south. We equally recognise concerns about the imbalance of needs

between the two areas, particularly in adult social care, but our judgement is that two councils would be better placed to understand, prioritise and respond to those differences.

Standing still is not an option for any council, let alone those undertaking reorganisation. There is no proposal that doesn't involve corporate and service delivery changes, and the best councils are already working on greater collaboration in areas and developing more effective neighbourhood footprints.

Criterion 4: Proposals should show how councils in the area have sought to work together in coming to a view that meets local needs and is informed by local views

The two unitary proposal meets criterion 4.

The two unitary proposal drew on engagement across all six districts. It provides clear evidence that councils sought residents' views and used them to shape the proposal. The Shape Worcestershire survey received around 4000 responses, mainly from residents. The councils also surveyed more than 700 staff, contacted all of its parish and town councils, and held many sessions with community groups, public service partners and other organisations. The proposal also has the support of most councils in the area. Of survey respondents who expressed a preference, roughly two thirds preferred two councils and around a third preferred one council. The proposal explains how this engagement shaped the north and south model. We consider this a clear strength, while recognising that these figures describe respondents' views, not those of all residents.

Turning to the one unitary proposal, which also meets criterion 4, we recognise there was engagement with partners and staff. While the county council ran an awareness campaign, the one unitary proposal did not provide evidence of consulting the public while developing its proposal. We therefore consider the two unitary proposal provides stronger evidence that local views informed its development. That is not to say that the proponents of the one unitary option did not put forward the proposal they believed best met this criterion, but that the consultation carried out for the two unitary proposal was able to demonstrate a good foundation of support for that proposal.

Criterion 5: New unitary structures must support devolution arrangements

The two unitary proposal meets criterion 5.

It would give the north and south distinct voices in a future strategic authority and greater flexibility over future devolution arrangements. Each council could represent its area's priorities on transport, skills, housing and investment, and influence how devolved funding is spent. The future devolution area remains open, but there are established partnerships with neighbouring counties that could provide the basis for a new devolution geography. We therefore consider the flexibility offered by two councils an important advantage, rather than assuming a particular future devolution arrangement.

Turning to the one unitary proposal, which also meets criterion 5, we recognise that a single council would have the scale to negotiate with regional partners and speak with one voice on transport, infrastructure and growth. However, we consider that the separate representation and flexibility offered by two councils make it the stronger proposal under this criterion.

Criterion 6: New unitary structures should enable stronger community engagement and deliver genuine opportunity for neighbourhood empowerment

The two unitary proposal meets criterion 6.

The two unitary proposal would create councils closer to their communities and better able to respond to the different needs of the north and south. The two unitary proposal sets out plans to establish Neighbourhood Area Committees where residents, councillors and partners could set priorities, help shape services and hold councils to account. Integrated Neighbourhood Teams would bring services

together around local needs, with a focus on prevention. The proposal points to the district councils' track record of community knowledge and strong partnerships, and having two councils better preserves this proximity to residents and communities.

Turning to the one unitary proposal, which also meets criterion 6, we recognise its commitment to local neighbourhood committees. These would bring together town and parish representatives, the council, voluntary groups, health services and the police. However, a countywide council risks being seen as more remote from local communities. We consider that two councils, supported by neighbourhood committees and teams, offer the stronger basis for local involvement and accountability. Together, our view is that this would give residents greater influence over decisions and services in their area. This closer link between each council and its communities is the proposal's main strength under this criterion.

It is important to note that the English Devolution and Community Empowerment Act 2026 requires all councils in England to make appropriate arrangements for effective neighbourhood governance in neighbourhood areas, with the Secretary of State able to make further provisions on those arrangements through regulations. Local government reorganisation provides an opportunity to embed this approach from the outset. Effective neighbourhood governance can help ensure that, within larger unitary structures, communities retain a strong local voice, are able to influence decisions affecting their area, and see their distinct identities and priorities reflected in how the new councils operate. We will publish a Neighbourhood Governance Framework later this year, which will provide new councils with some high-level principles to consider.

Conclusion

For the reasons set out above and considering both proposals' performance against the criteria in the round, the Secretary of State is currently minded to proceed with **the two unitary proposal submitted by Bromsgrove District Council, Malvern Hills District Council, Redditch Borough Council, Worcester City Council and Wychavon District Council.** The Secretary of State currently regards several factors as weighing particularly strongly. Its closer fit with the distinct economic geographies, housing needs and growth priorities of the north and south (criterion 1). It offers greater scope to organise public services around local needs, with early intervention and prevention supporting more cost-effective public services over time (criterion 3). It provides stronger evidence that local views shaped the proposal and has the support of most councils in the area (criterion 4). It would give the north and south distinct voices in a future strategic authority and greater flexibility over devolution arrangements (criterion 5). Its neighbourhood committees and teams, supported by councils closer to their communities, would give residents greater influence over local decisions and services (criterion 6). Together, these strengths underpin our judgement that it offers the better opportunity to improve local government services for Worcestershire.

The single unitary proposal provides the simplest structure and the stronger overall financial and efficiency case, and avoids the risks associated with disaggregation. But no reorganisation proposal is without significant corporate and service change, and that will present challenges whichever proposal is chosen. We have concluded that its advantages do not outweigh the two unitary proposal's benefits. These are, as always, balanced decisions, but we believe that, with the right support and focus, it could act as a strong foundation for the future of local government in this county.

Status of this provisional view

This letter does not constitute a final decision to implement this or any other proposal.

The conclusions set out above represent the Secretary of State's current provisional view, reached following consideration of the relevant material. Before reaching a final decision, the Secretary of State

will consider all representations received in response to this letter together with any other relevant material.

The Secretary of State remains open to reaching a different conclusion following that consideration, including modifying the provisionally preferred proposal further, deciding to implement a different proposal, or deciding not to implement any proposal.

Invitation for representations

Relevant councils and other interested parties will be invited to make representations on the provisional conclusions and reasoning set out in this letter. This representation period will be for a minimum of three weeks. We will confirm the exact timings shortly.

Representations should, where possible, address the provisional conclusions and any specific requests for information identified in this letter. We are grateful for the time already given to prepare and submit proposals, views and supporting evidence. There is no need to reproduce material submitted previously or repeat points that have already been made: that material will remain available to the Secretary of State and I when reaching the final decision.

The previous decision

The Secretary of State has today decided to withdraw the decision announced on 16 July 2026 concerning local government reorganisation in Worcestershire.

The Secretary of State and I are considering the proposals afresh and will reach a new final decision after considering the representations invited by this letter and any other relevant matters.

Statutory process

The Local Government and Public Involvement in Health Act 2007 provides the statutory framework for local government structural change. The statutory process permits the Secretary of State to implement a proposal with or without modification following the required consultation.

If, following the further consideration described in this letter, the Secretary of State decides to implement a proposal, the structural changes would need to be provided for in a structural changes order under section 7 of the 2007 Act, subject to the applicable Parliamentary procedure.

This letter does not itself establish any new council, alter any existing local government boundary or otherwise implement structural change.

Capacity funding and other matters

I recognise that councils have already incurred costs associated with preparing for local government reorganisation and have committed significant time, resource and leadership to this work.

I am pleased to confirm that Worcestershire will be paid 50% of the £900,000 per new unitary transition support funding. This is equal to £900,000. Grants will be paid in November to the previously confirmed recipient authority.

When final decisions are made, we will pay any remaining balance of the £900,000 transition support per each new unitary, taking account of funding already paid to its area, as well as £150,000 of supplementary funding per new unitary for Leadership Capacity and Continuity in Children’s Services, Adult Social Care and Public Health.

We are setting out further detail in the Written Ministerial Statement on city status and ceremonial matters, and the transition from the committee system.

I am copying this letter to your Chief Executives, MPs, and the West Mercia Police and Crime Commissioner.

Yours sincerely,



JIM MCMAHON OBE MP

Minister for Local Government, Devolution and Regional Growth